

Penny's dealings paved the way for nursing home

It sits imposingly at the corner of Greensboro and Penny roads, just on the High Point side of the Jamestown city limits. It's currently a convent for the Poor Sisters of the Mother of God, but the orange building shares a colorful past with the man who built it, George T. Penny.

Penny was born in 1877 in Randleman. According to Maryfield U.S.A., A Success Story, by Joe Exum Brown, "before he reached teen-age he and his brother James had started building a reputation as entrepreneurs who would one day strain the imaginations of newspaper writers to find words sufficiently extravagant to describe them."

The boys soon became horse traders, perhaps giving themselves the middle names of Trade and Cash.

As adults, the brothers organized Penny Bros. and billed themselves as the "World's Original Twin Auctioneers." Although widely known as the men who "speak at the same time and say the same thing in the same tone of voice," apparently the brothers were not actually twins.

Penny Bros. soon grew into a land brokerage business not only in North Carolina, but across the United States. George apparently had a rivalry with Tom Wrenn, one of High Point's wealthiest citizens and he often was the butt of George's business dealings.

Perhaps ironically, George Penny's house on Greensboro Road was across the street from Wrenn's summer home on the now-vacant property cleared several years ago to be developed as Wrenn Farm. After the property was cleared, the chimney from Wrenn's house could be seen from Greensboro Road.

In 1915, Penny's real estate sales amounted to over \$3,500,000, according to J.J. Farriss' book High Point in 1916.

Penny once owned property at the corner of Greensboro (Lexington) and Deep River roads at Five Points in High Point that became the Methodist Protestant Children's Home. Along with his brother, he helped finance the construction of the boys' dormitory, which was named Penny Hall.

He supposedly said, "The only money I ever saved was what I gave away," referring to his gift to the Methodist Protestant Children's Home.

When Penny decided to build his new house on the main road between High Point, Jamestown and Greensboro, he hired R.K. Stewart & Son in High Point for construction and Greensboro's Raleigh James Hughes as architect. Charles G. Mackintosh of High Point supervised landscaping of the 10 acres.

Dubbed "Pennybyrn," the house was in Italian Renaissance Revival design and cost \$126,000 to build in 1927. Preservation North Carolina notes "the exterior has cast stone trim framing arched windows and doors. Its hipped roof is supported by a modillion cornice of stone and details include relief carved into balconies under the second floor windows and in blind arches of the first floor."

George Stewart, grandson of R.K. Stewart, once said he had never seen a house built as well or with as much architectural detail as Pennybyrn.

"Penny is said to have described the house, soon after it was built, as 'a monument to nonsense,'" Brown

writes. "His wife was adamantly opposed to moving from their home in Greensboro to the rural setting."

The couple moved out after only five years.

Still owning the property, Penny rented the house and four-bay garage for several years after they moved out. At one time there was a furniture store and design center on the first floor, with the upstairs of the garage being used as an upholstery shop and sewing room.

A small article in the High Point Enterprise from Feb. 8, 1942, indicates the "Pennybyrne Supper Club had a highly successful opening last night as a jammed crowd gathered at the new night rendezvous for dancing and a floor show."

On July 3, 1946, the Enterprise ran an ad for The Chateau at the Penny estate. The restaurant featured luncheon and dinner, with a cocktail hour on Saturdays and a "special family dinner" on Sunday. The Chateau was available for wedding receptions, birthday parties, bridge luncheons and business meetings.

The next uses of Penny's home were tamer ? a nursing home and convent.

When the five Poor Sisters of the Mother of God came to America from Ireland in 1947, they lived in the garage apartment as they formulated plans to open a hospital in the house. The hospital did not materialize and it was at that time the order purchased the house and used it as a nursing home. Edward Cordick, Development and Community Relations at today's Pennybyrn, said there were 20 beds downstairs and the sisters lived upstairs. Undoubtedly some of these beds were in the large living room, over 20 feet in length.

When the sisters were able to construct the new Maryfield Nursing Home, the Penny house became their convent.

"Practically all the fine old woodwork, brass hardware and beamed ceilings (sic) have been preserved," read an Enterprise article from March 17, 1968, about the opening of the convent.

Cordick said detailed handcarved chestnut woodwork still exists in the building and the large living room contains a fireplace.

Penny's donation to the Methodist Protestant Orphanage and sale of the property to the sisters of the Poor Servants of the Mother of God seem in contradiction to his everyday personality.

He was obviously a wheeler-dealer and apparently made and lost several fortunes over his lifetime.

J.J. Farriss wrote in 1906, "His word was as good as his bond anywhere he is known and his counsel and aid is sought in many lines of business."

However, he "liked nothing better than skinning the wealthy," wrote former Enterprise editor Holt McPherson in 1961. "He became a legend in his own time. Penny fastened himself upon this community around the turn of the century to make himself always an interesting, and at times a sinister, face in its development."

The book High Pointers of High Point notes this about Penny's character: "A shrewd and glib trader, Penny felt it his bounden duty to persuade some of the successful manufacturers to diversify their interests ? and he unloaded upon them some of the most questionable properties here and elsewhere ? especially around Washington, D.C. ? to his own enrichment, while they wrung their hands for letting themselves be taken

in by his swindles."

George Penny passed away Oct. 8, 1961, at the age of 84. Among his other business ventures was the Carolina Loan and Realty Co., Southern Livestock Insurance Co., a hosiery mill in Galax, Va.; the Moffitt Underwear Co. in High Point; Mincie Manufacturing in Georgia; and a medicinal salve business called Hep-U-Rub. Penny also served three times as North Carolina state senator in the 1940s.

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